in the largest cricket market, sell them by auction to the owners of private franchises based in large stadiums and major cities, create a league with a double round-robin format followed by knockout stages and a final, add razzamatazz and play.

Sporting organisations tend to be criticised, and the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) received its share of flak over the years, not least for declining to use technology and the review system, and for their intransigence in arranging tour schedules. However, to be fair, the history books will record that it was the BCCI that got the job done and, in 2008, created the tournament that transformed the game. It was the BCCI that built the platform on which cricketers were suddenly being paid up to US$1.5 million to perform for seven weeks.

Their fellow administrators around the world recoiled in shock.

Some responded by figuratively plunging their collective heads into the nearest bucket of sand, trying to pretend that the IPL did not exist; these governing bodies arranged international fixtures at the same time as the new league and so sought to prevent their leading players from taking the opportunity.

Fortunately for me, and many other South African players, Cricket South Africa immediately adopted a more enlightened and proactive approach, embracing the concept of the new league, ensuring the Proteas would never play in the same time window, and so enabling our players to enter the auction and participate.

'AB, you've been bought for US$300 000 per year.'

'What?'

'Serious! You've been bought for US$300 000 per year, and it's a three-year deal.'

It was true. I had been entered into the inaugural IPL auction, and been bought by a team called the Delhi Daredevils (DD) for US$300 000 per year. Around the world, disbelieving cricketers double-checked the numbers.